SET FOR A ONE-SIDED SHOWDOWN

FRESH FROM ITS ASSEMBLY POLL WIN, THE BJP IS EYEING A HAT TRICK OF CLEAN SWEEPS. A CHASTENED CONGRESS IS MOUNTING A CHALLENGE PEGGED TO REALISTIC GOALS. WHAT IT CONFRONTS IS THE MODI FACTOR

BY ROHIT PARIHAR



AS PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI BARNSTORMS ACROSS RAJASTHAN ahead of the Lok Sabha election, there is a striking change in his demeanour. Gone is the stern, stoic figure that spearheaded the Bharatiya Janata Party's campaign during the assembly election a mere six months ago. Back then, Modi maintained an impeccably sombre mien, eschewing even the most perfunctory of greetings to those sharing the dais. It was a studied aloofness to avoid any hint of favouritism amidst the jostling ambitions of the state's political heavyweights. But now, a distinctly more relaxed Modi exhibits an animated canvas of smiles and warmth as he engages freely with the local leaders, even welcoming their company during road shows and rallies.

Led by Modi, the BJP had defeated the ruling Congress in the assembly election held last November. The comfortable majority it cornered has further cemented the party's position in the desert state, where it had a clean sweep in the past two Lok Sabha elections—alone in 2014 and with then ally Rashtriya Loktantrik Party (RLP) in 2019. And yet again, the party has rallied its forces around a singular figure: Narendra Modi. As the PM seeks

SAFFRON SURGE

Within a decade, the BJP vote share saw a 22 percentage point rise in the Lok Sabha elections held in Rajasthan; the recent assembly poll win has taken it a step closer to a third good outing in a row

